Michelle Star

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Education

University of Pittsburgh, Apr. 2026
Honors College, **School of Computing and Information** (*summa cum laude*)
Bachelor of Philosophy in Data Science, *Specialization: Data Analytics* | Minor: Computer Science
Thesis: "Evaluating Supportive LLM Behavior Across User Contexts Using Simulated Multi-Turn Conversations"
Faculty Mentor: Dr. Yu-Ru Lin
Honors: David C. Frederick, *Honors Distinction*

Taylor Allderdice High School (*Valedictorian)* Pittsburgh, PA Jun. 2022

Publication

Michelle Star. 2026. Evaluating Supportive LLM Behavior Over Multiple Turns across Demographics. In Extended Abstracts of the 2026 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '26), April 13–17, 2026, Barcelona, Spain. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 4 pages. https://doi.org/10.1145/3772363.3799175
Student Research Competition - sole author, 1 of 12 selected worldwide

Star, M., Aquilina, A., & Lin, Y.-R. (2026). Auditing support strategies in LLMs through grounded multi-turn social simulation. In Proceedings of the SocialLLM Workshop at the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM). https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2604.17079
Oral Presentation - awarded to top 25% of accepted papers

Research Experience

***Undergraduate Researcher,* BPhil Thesis, University of Pittsburgh** 2025–Present
- Investigating support variance and emergent bias in LLMs across demographic subcommunities on Reddit.
- Using NLP and multi-turn simulations to analyze linguistic sentiment and support quality to reveal discrepancies.
- Conducting original research to be defended before a committee of faculty and experts in the field.

***Volunteer Research Assistant*, CivicWatch, PICSO Lab** 2025–Present
- Extracted and classified political discourse on social media for legislative transparency research.
- Worked on NLP modeling and front-end design to improve civic accessibility and reduce misinformation.

Internships

***Data Science Capstone*, Latitude AI (Ford Subdivision)** 2025–Present
- Designed and built a data pipeline to aggregate and analyze road work zone data utilizing open-source data from across the U.S., supporting the safety of autonomous vehicle navigation.
- Processed and standardized diverse datasets to provide real-time construction zone awareness for integration into Ford's self-driving systems.

***UX/UI Designer*, Osher Lifelong Learning Institute** 2025–Present
- Leading a website redesign initiative to improve modernity, accessibility, and usability for an older adult audience.
- Conducted user experience research to identify pain points in the current interface, focusing on screen reader compatibility and intuitive information flow.
- Implementing accessibility best practices (WCAG) to ensure content is perceivable, navigable, and user-friendly for individuals with visual or cognitive impairments.

Leadership & Mentorship Experience

***Appointed Student Representative*, Academic Council, School of Computing and Information** 2025–Present
- Selected by the Dean as one of two undergraduates to represent students in school-wide curricular governance.

- Participated in monthly council meetings to review, deliberate, and vote on proposed changes to academic programs, degree requirements, and policies.

***Mentor*, Women in Computer Science Club & CS Club, University of Pittsburgh** 2025–Present

- Mentored 5 undergraduates in academic success, career exploration, and navigating the tech field.
- Guided on course planning, research/internship opportunities, hackathons, and professional communication.
- Fostering confidence and retention of women in tech by sharing resources and facilitating networking opportunities.

***Program Director,* YMCA Camp Kon-O-Kwee Spencer** 2021-2025

- Directed experiential learning programs for 560+ youth campers, overseeing two departments.
- Mentored and evaluated a team of 20 staff, emphasizing skill development, iterative performance feedback.
- Partnered with healthcare professionals to co-develop accessible camp experiences for children with Hemophilia and Charcot-Marie-Tooth, incorporating accessibility principles into educational design.

***Extended Day Counselor*, St. Edmund's Academy** 2023-Present

- Independently facilitated structured after-school learning for 40+ students.
- Acted as primary educator in the absence of teachers, supported behavioral needs across a diverse student population.
- Provided individualized math tutoring and homework assistance to reinforce classroom learning.

Selected Projects

***Team Leader*, Wireless Innovation Hackathon for Accessibility** - *First Place Winner* - (*$1,500 Prize*) Oct. 2025

- Created a platform to simplify access to wheelchair-accessible vehicles (WAVs) using LLM-powered agents that contact transportation providers on users' behalf.
- Collaborated with a community member with Cerebral Palsy to ensure real-world relevance and usability.
- Built with Google Maps API integration, enabling route comparison and integrated WCAG-compliant UI features.
- Recognized for innovation, inclusive design, and societal impact by a cross-disciplinary panel of judges.

Prevalence of Heavy Drinking Survey Study Apr. 2025

- Developed questionnaire and cluster sampling method covering demographics, consequences, and perceptions.
- Created plans to minimize non-response bias (reminders, incentives, weighting) and control measurement error.

Pitt Challenge Hackathon - *Winner of GoDaddy Registry Prize* Sept. 2023

- Developed "*No Nurses Left Behind*," a social media platform aimed at combating medical professional burnout.
- Integrated an AI chatbot using Python to provide real-time emotional support.

Presentations

***Student Research Competition*, CHI 2026** Apr. 2026

- ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, Barcelona, Spain
- Sole author, 1 of 12 extended abstracts selected worldwide.

***Higher Ed Student Spotlight*, The Global Impact Forum (TGIF)** Nov. 2025

- Selected to present AI accessibility project MobilU to an audience of 300+ global leaders across industries.
- The event featured networking, keynote speakers, and a showcase of interdisciplinary impact initiatives.

Awards & Scholarships:

Academic Merit Scholarship	2022 - Present
Pittsburgh Public Scholar	2022 - Present
Dean's List - School of Computing and Information	2023 - Present
Portrait Master Award - La Roche College	2022

Skills: Programming Languages: R, Python, Java, SQL, JavaScript, HTML, Assembly
Tools & Environments: RStudio, Visual Studio, Git, Jupyter, Mars, Figma, Logism
Data Science Tools: tidyverse, ggplot2, caret, Pandas, Matplotlib, keyBERT, HuggingFace

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Certifications: *Disabling Ableism: Allyship and Advocacy Badge* (SHRS, University of Pittsburgh)
Programming Foundations with JavaScript, HTML, and CSS (Duke University, Coursera)